

Chapter 1

The Mark of the Beast

Over the centuries, the mark of the beast has caused much confusion among Christians, endless theological debates, and evolving technology has never offered a clue as to what the mark will be. With the mark of the beast undoubtedly being a central piece, a kernel of the Antichrist's scheme operations in the end times. The focus on the understanding of the mark should not be speculations of what it will be, but rather, its significance from pieces of evidence given to us through the Bible, and the solution to the mark of the beast that these evidence guide us to.

Instead of speculating about barcodes or microchips, let us piece together the evidence found in the lines of the Bible. You may be surprised by truly how much information are dispersed throughout the scriptures, and by piecing the jigsaw together through examining the verses collectively, even more astounded by the coherent picture that emerges concerning the Antichrist and his mark. Equipped with the word of God, let us come to the full knowledge of the devil's schemes behind the mark of the beast, which are the significance of the forehead and right hand, the significance of its number, the identity behind the Antichrist and the False Prophet, its deceptive incentive, its dire consequences, and finally its solution.

Significance of Forehead and Right Hand

It might seem rather unimportant where the mark of the beast is physically located on the human body, but the Bible is specific about this for a reason. The devil selecting these two particular places of the body, the forehead and the right hand, is no coincidence, but in fact a blatant imitation of what God has done and will do for His people. We will see that our adversary is not a fool, but a deceptively cunning strategist, and his stratagem behind the mark of the beast is simple yet cunningly sinister.

The Forehead

In the scripture, the forehead is more than just an ordinary part of the body, it represents something profound in God's relationship with man. To understand this significance, we begin in the Old Testament in a time when God was laying out the rules for establishing a covenant relationship with His people. In Exodus chapter 28, God instructs Moses regarding the garment and attire of the high priest. Concerning the turban, God commands that a plate of pure gold be placed on it with engravings that display, "Holiness to Jehovah". This plate of pure gold with the engraving is fastened to the front of the turban (Exo. 28:37), that is, the forehead of the high priest. In fact, God says that this engraved plate shall always be placed on the high priest's forehead (Exo. 28:38) so that the offerings may be accepted before Him.

In the New Testament, when the Lord was asked the difficult question of what the most important commandment in the scriptures, Jesus's reply was clear: "love the Lord with all your heart, and all your soul, and all your mind, and all your strength" (Mark 12:30). In reference back to the first time the Lord said this to the children of Israel in Deuteronomy chapter 6, the Lord continued with the explanation of the commandment: "and these words, which I command you today, shall be upon your heart... and you shall bind them on your hand as a sign, and they shall be as frontlets between your eyes" (Deut. 6:8). With the hand and frontlets of one's eyes being the hand and the forehead, the Hebrew word for "sign" can be translated also as "mark" or "ensign". It is fascinating that the only two physical body parts mentioned in relation to the first commandment of the scriptures are the hand and the forehead, with the writing on the forehead and hand later developing into the Shema, the Jewish prayer of devotion to God, a symbol of devoting one's entire being to God. It is clear that God is commanding the Israelites to mark their foreheads as a sign of their complete love for Him, to represent that this commandment is at the forefront of one's body and mind.

It is rather sinister when the Antichrist comes, he will choose to physically distribute his mark on the foreheads of all the peoples of the earth (Rev. 13:7, 14). In fact, did you know that something like this has already happened in history? Going one step beyond the metaphorical representation of the forehead in our devotion to the Lord in the two previous examples, a biblical event provides even more insight into the placement of the mark and the fate of those who receive it.

In the book of Ezekiel, the prophet sees a vision of Jerusalem under siege, where the judgement of God is coming upon the people of Israel and of Judah because of their very, very great iniquity. In this vision, God sent forth a man clothed in linen, with a scribe's inkhorn by his side, to put a mark on the forehead of all the people in Jerusalem who are mourning and groaning over the iniquities being committed in the land (Ezek. 9:4). God then declared, all that does not have the mark, the old man and young man, the maiden, the women and the children would be slain (Ezek. 9:6; cf. Rev. 13:15-16). With the mark in Ezekiel in Hebrew denoting a "signature" according to Strong's concordance, a stark cross-reference to how God's people will have His name upon their foreheads in Revelation chapter 22, the final chapter of the Bible.

Ezekiel's vision of God's mark upon their foreheads is an inversion of John's vision of the mark of the beast in Revelation, or rather, the mark of the beast being the imitation and inversion of God's mark of salvation. Through piecing together the scriptures, we realise that the mark upon one's forehead represent one's allegiance and ownership to the one giving the mark, just like the doorposts that were marked with blood of the lamb in Exodus when God passed over the whole of Egypt executing judgement, those marked on the forehead by God in Ezekiel were passed over as well (Ezek. 9:6).

Going back to Revelation, we see the continuation of the mark of God, which concurrently opposes the mark of the beast. In the vision inserted between the sixth and seventh seal in chapter 7, we are told that the 144,000 from the twelve tribes of Israel preserved on earth by God shall be marked with the seal of God upon their foreheads (Rev. 7:3, 9:4). And ultimately in the last chapter of the Bible, continuing after the millennium and into the New Jerusalem, God's name will remain on the foreheads of His people (Rev. 22:4), while the Antichrist and those with his mark are forever perishing in the lake of fire (Rev. 14:9-11, 19:20).

Just as how one put his name upon something to mark it for his claim, ownership, or possession, the mark of God is the name Christ and the name of God the Father (Rev. 14:1), while the opposite, the mark of the beast is the name the Antichrist (Rev. 13:17), which will be discussed in greater depth later in this chapter. Therefore, at the end times, there will be two marks operating in opposition to each other, one of the true Christ, and one of the Antichrist, both as an inscription and a claim to people with the names of the respective owners of the marks.

The Right Hand

While the forehead isn't the only location on the human body revealed in the Bible that people will receive the mark on, let us also understand why the right hand, in particular, is chosen by the devil and its significance to all parties involved in the end times. Indeed, after some in-depth research, it is convincing to say that this choice by the devil was likewise no coincidence.

Scripture reveals three things that the right hand symbolises. Number one, swearing, or the making of an oath. In the book of Isaiah, God swears by His righteous right hand that He will uphold Israel (Isa. 41:10). He also swears by His right hand and His mighty arm that when He establishes Jerusalem, Israel will never again be plundered by its enemies (Isa. 62:8). Hence, we see that God swears and establishes oaths with His people by His right hand, and evidence does not stop here. Let us travel further back in the Bible to see the picture of God's establishment of a covenant relationship with His people when He led them out of Egypt. We see in Leviticus that Moses anoints Aaron the high priest, whose position is the mediator of the covenant in the Old Testament, on his right foot, right ear, and right hand (Lev. 8:23). And going into the New Testament, the establishment of the new covenant come through Jesus, who is now being at the right hand of God (Rom. 3:34). Because of this, it is reasonable to assume receiving the mark of the beast on one's right hand represents one swearing a covenant relationship with the devil.

The second significance of the right hand is blessing. In Genesis, after Joseph is reunited with his family in Egypt, his father Jacob blessed Joseph's sons before leaving to be with the Lord. The blessing is given by placing his right hand upon the boy's head (Gen. 48:18). King David also echoes this idea many times throughout the book of Psalms. Psalms 16 says: "You will make known to me the path of life; in Your presence is fullness of joy; at Your right hand there are

pleasures forever”. David also exclaims how God shows His wondrous lovingkindness and saves by His right hand (Psa. 17:7). This significance is equally present in the New Testament. When revealing the things concerning the end of the age, Jesus refers to the people living on the earth as “sheep” and “goats”, with the important detail that the sheep are set on His right hand, receiving blessing and inheritance from God (Matt. 25:33-34).

The third significance of the right hand is the representable of strength and action, with one of the signs of the commandment to love the Lord with all our heart, soul, and strength is to bind it as a sign on our hand (Deut. 6:8). In Exodus chapter 15, God’s right hand was credited by Moses and the children of Israel with the smashing of the army of the Egyptians. “Your right hand, O Jehovah, is glorious in power. Your right hand, O Jehovah, dashed the enemy in pieces” (Exo. 15:6). King David, being a man of military prowess, referred to the power of the Lord’s right hand multiple times throughout the psalms. In Psalm 20, David writes that the Lord will save His anointed with the saving might of His right hand (Psa. 20:6). We’re told in Psalm 44 that Israel’s conquest of old, were not done through Israel’s own power or strength, but through the right hand and arm of God, and further mentions of the awesomeness and might of are a common occurrence throughout the Psalms (Psa. 45:4, 45:9, 60:5, 63:8, 89:13, 91:7, 108:6, 138:7). In addition to the power, might, and strength of God represented by the right hand, God also shares in His might, to sustain and strengthen us by taking hold of our right hand (Psa. 73:23; Isa. 41:10, 41:13).

So how can these meanings and passages from the Bible help us in understanding the mark of the beast? Well, we see that the right hand represents covenant (the making of an oath), blessing, and strength when attributed to God. And for us, man, who is the image of God (Gen. 1:26), we can shake hands with someone to make a deal with deal, we can bless someone by laying our hand upon them (Gen. 48:18; 2 Tim. 1:6), or by simply giving them food or helping them up, and you can create and build using the strength of your hands as well as fight and protect yourself. Therefore, it is no coincidence that the Antichrist chose to mark the people on our right hand and forehead. With foreheads marked by the Antichrist, people are effectively owned and taken possession of by the Antichrist; and with right hands marked, people effectively partner with him, bless him, and give their strength to serving the Antichrist.